



offline distribution to students. This has helped teachers to cater to some specific requirements like facilitating revision and better retention among children.

What they achieved

After getting trained on Web tools by CII-Shiksha, teachers created their own Web platforms like blogs, wikis and social

networks. They are using blogs to deliver the teaching-learning process, posting lessons, activities, assignments, student projects, etc. Many teachers used blogs during the summer vacation and other holiday breaks to stay connected with the students and keep them engaged. Similarly, the use of wikis is effective in involving students in various class projects, posting

assignments, exercises, etc. Social networks are being exploited effectively to create knowledge community for students and teachers alike.

The initiative is effective even in addressing the needs of special education. As per Bhatia, "Using Shiksha content with differently abled children resulted in better understanding and retention." ■

A One-Stop Shop for Electronic Components and Equipment

From a modest beginning in June 2008 to successfully holding an authoritative position in the value chain of India's electronics sector, Farnell India has traversed a long way within a pretty short span of time. In an exclusive interview with *Electronics For You*, Ravi Pagar, managing director, Farnell India, shares his thoughts regarding expansion of the customer base in the education sector

Sudeshna Das

Farnell India is working with the education sector with a strategy that has changed from a generic one to a more client-specific one with the concept of "small volume, high mix." While most distributors give preference to order quantity over product mix, Farnell offers a huge range of diversified products from around 3500 electronics manufacturers across the world with no rigidity about minimum order quantity. It even goes to the extent of providing a single piece of component or circuit required by a student for building a design prototype for an educational project.

"With our 'small volume, high mix' supplying policy, we aim to build an electronic design engineering (EDE) community of Indian students as our future customers," says Pagar.

Innovative networking

Though Farnell India has adopted a multicomponent approach in building and retaining relationship with the education sector, at the heart of it all is a common string—making their customers aware

and well connected. Farnell India believes in communication as well as value addition. This is clearly evident in their new venture Element-14—a unique attempt to connect the global electronics design engineering community. Pagar prefers to address it as LinkedIn or Facebook for the EDE community. Access to a knowledge portal consisting of datasheets, protocols, pictures and even ROHS activities is only a click away.

With specific requirements being present across various aspects of the education sector, distributors need to communicate in a special way. "Farnell is maintaining special dedicated channels to better cater to the education domain," says Pagar. In order to encourage innovative electronics design ideas, Farnell introduced 2008 Live EDGE Electronic Design Global Environment Challenge for electronics students as well as professionals. The programme is extended in the form of Live EDGE scholarships for students worldwide enrolling for an electrical and electronics engineering course in the year 2009. The prize money will be evenly distributed between Asia, Europe



Ravi Pagar, managing director, Farnell India

and the Americas, allotting \$10,000 for each region.

Adding value

Farnell has always maintained a sophisticated and dynamic business model and excelled at key account management.

In order to add value to the teaching and learning process, it has organised valuable training programmes at educational institutes on behalf of its vendors like Microchip and Texas Instruments.

Using the team of experts of its Global Tech Support Center in Bangalore, Farnell can provide support to any institute in setting up a ready-to-use electronics laboratory. As per Pagar, "Farnell is a one-stop shop for electronics component and equipment." It may even help customers to procure products which are not available in its basket.

Additionally, since Farnell has worked with a wide range of customers across sectors, geographies and projects of varying levels of complexity, it has a rich repository of information and experience. This aids in refining its delivery methodology as past learnings are immediately implemented into a new project. ■